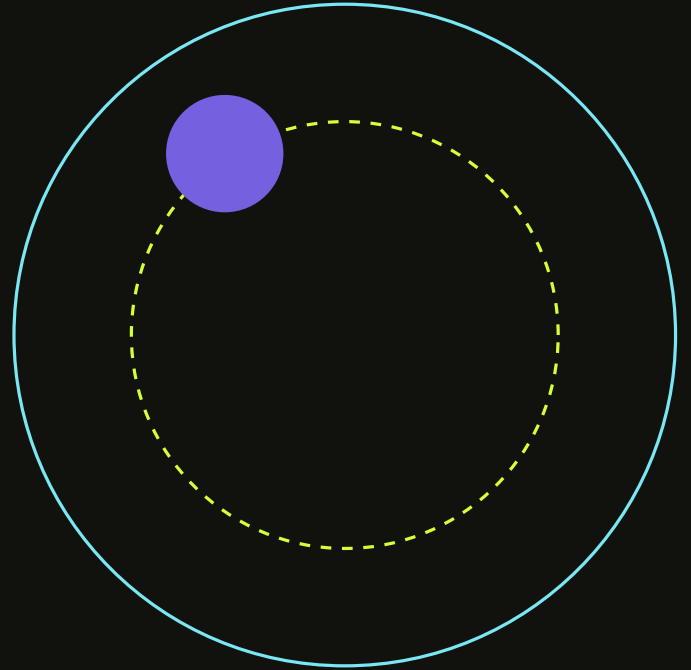


MAKE AI USEFUL FIRST.



Five practical systems for clearer work, sharper decisions
and automations worth keeping.

FOR OPERATORS, FOUNDERS AND CURIOUS BUILDERS

Hacks² / Applied AI

AI IS NOT A TOOL STACK.

The useful part of AI is not collecting apps or writing a clever one-off prompt. It is building a small number of repeatable systems that improve a real piece of work.

Use this pack in 30 minutes:

- 1 Choose one task you repeat every week.
- 2 Run one workflow exactly as written.
- 3 Keep the useful output and change one thing next time.



H²

THE OPERATING LOOP

THE PROBLEM

AI output feels inconsistent when each task starts from a blank page and the success criteria live only in your head.

THE OUTCOME

A repeatable loop: brief -> draft -> review -> decision -> saved pattern.

RUN THE WORKFLOW

- 1 Write a one-sentence job to be done and name the decision or deliverable it must support.
- 2 Give AI the relevant context, constraints and an explicit output format.
- 3 Review against three criteria: accuracy, usefulness and voice. Correct the weak point, not everything.
- 4 Save the final prompt, the best example and one lesson for the next run.

COPY / ADAPT THIS PROMPT

Act as a practical collaborator. My job: [job]. Context: [context]. Constraints: [constraints]. Produce: [format]. Before answering, state the 3 assumptions that could make this output wrong.

MEASURE Track: time from task start to usable output. Aim to reduce it after three runs.

PROMPT ARCHITECTURE

THE PROBLEM

Long prompts often hide the actual ask. Short prompts often omit the context that makes a result usable.

THE OUTCOME

A clear request that gives the model enough information to make useful trade-offs.

RUN THE WORKFLOW

- 1 Start with the role only when it changes the perspective: editor, analyst, strategist or support lead.
- 2 State the task in one direct sentence. Then add only the context the model cannot infer.
- 3 List hard constraints: audience, source limits, tone, budget, deadline or things to avoid.
- 4 Specify the output shape: table, decision memo, checklist, email or step-by-step plan.

COPY / ADAPT THIS PROMPT

You are [role]. Complete this task: [task]. Use this context: [context]. Respect: [constraints]. Return the result as: [output format]. If information is missing, ask up to 3 targeted questions before making assumptions.

MEASURE Track: number of rewrites needed before you can use the result.

RESEARCH TO DECISION

THE PROBLEM

Research becomes a pile of tabs when there is no agreed question, evidence standard or decision at the end.

THE OUTCOME

A short decision brief that separates facts, inference and unknowns.

RUN THE WORKFLOW

- 1 Write the decision question before gathering sources. Example: Which tool should we adopt for support triage this quarter?
- 2 Collect 3-5 credible sources. Capture claims, dates, costs and direct evidence - not just summaries.
- 3 Ask AI to group evidence into options, benefits, trade-offs and risks. Make it cite the source for every factual claim.
- 4 Choose a recommendation, an owner, a next action and a date to revisit the decision.

COPY / ADAPT THIS PROMPT

Create a decision brief from these sources: [paste notes/links]. Decision question: [question]. Return: 1) verified facts with sources, 2) options, 3) risks and unknowns, 4) recommendation with confidence level, 5) next action. Clearly label inference versus evidence.

MEASURE Track: time between opening research and making a documented decision.

AUTOMATION ROI

THE PROBLEM

An automation can look impressive while quietly costing more in setup, subscriptions and maintenance than it saves.

THE OUTCOME

A simple go/no-go decision before you build.

RUN THE WORKFLOW

- 1 Estimate how often the task happens each month and how many minutes each run currently takes.
- 2 Estimate realistic time saved per run - not the full task unless the automation actually replaces it.
- 3 Multiply saved hours by a fair hourly value. Subtract monthly tool costs and spread setup cost over 6-12 months.
- 4 Build only if the payoff is meaningful, the failure mode is acceptable and someone owns maintenance.

COPY / ADAPT THIS PROMPT

Help me assess an automation. Task frequency: [x/month]. Current minutes per run: [x]. Minutes saved per run: [x]. Hourly value: [x]. Monthly software cost: [x]. Setup hours: [x]. Calculate monthly net value, payback period and the 3 biggest operational risks.

MEASURE Use the Hacks² ROI Calculator. Keep a record of estimated vs actual time saved after 30 days.

WEEKLY REVIEW RITUAL

THE PROBLEM

Without a review, useful AI work gets lost, weak automations keep running and your tool stack grows without improving the work.

THE OUTCOME

A 20-minute weekly habit that compounds the value of the systems you already use.

RUN THE WORKFLOW

- 1 List the AI tasks you used this week. Mark each as keep, improve or stop.
- 2 Pick one output that saved time and save the prompt, context and final example in your operating notes.
- 3 Pick one output that failed. Identify whether the cause was missing context, a bad workflow or a tool limitation.
- 4 Choose one small experiment for next week. It must have a measurable result and an owner.

COPY / ADAPT THIS PROMPT

Run a weekly AI operations review. Here are this week's tasks and outcomes: [paste notes]. Return a table with Keep / Improve / Stop, the reason for each, one reusable pattern to document, and one experiment for next week with a success metric.

MEASURE

Track: one documented reusable pattern and one stopped low-value activity every week.

STOP COLLECTING.

START BUILDING.

Pick one workflow. Run it this week. Keep the result only if it improves a real decision, deliverable or routine.

CONTINUE WITH HACKS²

Workflows, field notes and practical tools for applied AI.

hacks2.com ■